A Taste of Honey: Writer's Methods and Techniques

Exam code: 0475 & 0992

Download PDF

Written by: Sam Evans
Reviewed by: Nick Redgrove
Updated on 30 September 2025

Shelagh Delaney employs various dramatic devices and literary techniques to convey meaning and deliver messages. The exam question on A Taste of Honey requires you to analyse methods, which means you should consider how Delaney's choices affect how an audience reacts. Here we will explore the way Delaney uses:

- Form and structure
- Stagecraft
- Language
- Imagery and symbolism

Form and structure

Shelagh Delaney's play is a **kitchen sink drama**, which means the play is a realistic depiction of ordinary individuals' lives, and that it portrays the struggles of working-class life.

It is useful to consider the genre of the play in your analysis as this is a key writer's method. With this in mind, it is worth analysing the way the play uses dramatic conventions.

- The play is divided into two acts that consist of two scenes:
  - Act 1 introduces single mother Helen and her teen daughter Jo moving into a rundown flat
  - Act 2 jumps to several months later when Jo is pregnant: the setting is now Jo's flat (small, sparsely furnished)
- Delaney uses a **cyclical structure** to reflect a cycle of poverty for the **working class**:
  - In Act 1, Helen says to Jo: "That's where we all end up sooner or later"
  - By Act 2, Jo says: "So we're back where we started"
- When Jo leaves home, she finds herself in a similar situation to her mother, which presents ideas about generational cycles:
  - In the exposition, Helen says that Jo, like her, is "not very fond of work"
  - In Act 2, Jo's flat is messy: Geof comments, "I can tell it's yours from the state it's in"

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

got to work all day in a shoe shop and all night in a bar to pay for it"

Examiner Tips and Tricks

In your response to the exam question on A Taste of Honey, it is best to refer to the way the play shows the progression of Jo's life, and how her future is determined by her mother's struggles.

For example, in Act 1 Helen is criticised for not providing a better home for her daughter. However, in Act 2 audiences see Jo living in similarly poor conditions and facing a life of poverty as a single mother.

Help me understand

Stagecraft

- Delaney's **naturalistic** style presents a brutally honest depiction of social issues in 1950s England
- The play is an example of **social realism**:
  - It portrays **working-class** characters disillusioned with modern society
  - Helen and Jo's rundown flat is in an industrial area in the North of England
  - Jo is underfed, and Helen resorts to drinking and **promiscuity**
- Delaney breaks the **fourth wall** to create audience engagement:
  - When Helen and Jo argue, they often comment to the audience, referring to each other in the third person
  - Helen asks for support from the audience: "Wouldn't she get on your nerves?"
  - Jo's comments raise key ideas: "So that's what she was running away from"
- Delaney uses music to signal key events:
  - There is jazz music playing when Jo and Helen move into their flat
  - Helen sings when she has fond memories of a freer life: "I thought it was wonderful... You know, playing the piano and all that"
  - Music accompanies Peter's fateful arrival
- Nursery rhymes represent the idea of motherhood and a happy childhood:
  - Children sing nursery rhymes outside Jo and Helen's flat, which serves to emphasise Jo's lack of a real childhood
- Often, music accompanies moments when Jo and Helen feel hopeful:
  - A traditional wedding song "Here Comes the Bride" plays when Helen and Peter plan to marry

- Jo sings a song to end the play as she thinks about Geof

Language

- Delaney's script is made up of colloquialisms and **regional dialect**:
  - Helen tells Jo: "You're asking for a bloody good hiding, lady"
  - She says of Peter's arrival, "Look what the wind's blown in"
  - Jo remarks about being in films: "I'd sooner be put on't streets. It's more honest"
- Characters insult each other regularly when they feel unsupported or disrespected:
  - This creates a dark humour which shows how troubled individuals mask painful feelings or take their disappointments out on each other
  - For example, when Helen tells Jo she is always "bathing", Jo replies, "I'm not like you. I don't wait until it becomes necessary before I have a good wash"
- Sarcasm portrays characters attempting to be resilient while feeling powerless:
  - Helen's **self-deprecating** comments conveys a lack of self-esteem, while also creating humour:
    - She tells Jo, "I know, I'm a cruel, wicked woman"
  - Helen jokes about her terrible living conditions, saying her bed is "Like a coffin only not half as comfortable"

Imagery and symbolism

- Delaney uses symbolism to highlight key themes
- Engagement rings symbolise fragile or uncertain relationships
- Helen values rings as tokens of financial security, while Jo wears hers around her neck to show her hesitation about marriage:
  - When Peter asks Helen if the "little lady" wants an engagement ring, Jo says their "courtship had passed the stage of symbolism"
  - Delaney shows Helen willing to give up her dignity for the "odd diamond ring"
  - Jo wears her engagement ring around her neck, perhaps because of her uncertain feelings about marriage
- Personal belongings contribute to Delaney's characterisations:
  - Peter's wallet full of pictures of other women represents his deceit
  - Jimmie (the Boy) has a "toy car" in his pocket, implying innocence

flowers
- When Jo plants flower bulbs, she says “I hope they bloom. Always before when I've tried to fix up a window box nothin's ever grown in it”

Sources

Delaney, Shelagh (2008), *A Taste Of Honey* (Edited by Glenda Leeming and Elaine Aston), Bloomsbury Academic.

Capitani, Maria Elena, 'A New Reality: Shelagh Delaney's A Taste oHoney (1958)', in Sue Kennedy, and Jane Thomas (eds), British Women's Writing, 1930 to 1960: Between the Waves (Liverpool, 2020; online edn, Liverpool Scholarship Online, 20 May 2021), https://doi.org/10.3828/liverpool/9781789621822.003.0013, accessed 22 Sept. 2025.

Teacher only

Test your students on this in just a few clicks

- Create exam-aligned tests
- Tailor format & difficulty
- Quizzes or homework in minutes

Try Test Builder →

Test yourself

Was this revision note helpful? Yes No

Past Papers
Solution Banks
Sitemap

Company

About us
Exam Specificity
Content Quality
Promotions
Jobs
Terms
Privacy
Cookie Policy
Help and Support

Subscription
Settings
Log out

Subjects

Biology
Chemistry
Physics
Maths
Geography
English Literature
Psychology
All Subjects

© Copyright 2015–2026 Save My Exams Ltd. All Rights Reserved.
Neither IBO nor College Board were involved in the production of, and do not endorse, the resources created by Save My Exams.